eight. Usually, he rang the bell on his desk, signaling to Frau Birks to bring tea. But tonight, he started reading, his slender finger tracing down the center of the page as Rose waited.

“Nineteen Russian women,” he said, leaning back in his chair. “One dead.” He reached for the small glass on his desk and downed the liquid inside, wincing as it hit the back of his throat.

She smelled alcohol and a hint of anise—schnapps. “It’s curious, isn’t it, Rose?”

“Curious?”

“Yes. Russians arriving now when the war is nearly over?” His glassy blue eyes stared at her.

He seemed particularly cold tonight. Rose wondered if her lateness annoyed him or if he’d been drinking schnapps for some time before she’d arrived. He usually liked it when she gave him her undivided attention, so she leaned forward, hoping to encourage him to talk and let her leave early.

“Do you think we would have been friends if we’d met in other circumstances?” he asked.

“I don’t know. Perhaps.”

“We’re so similar, both orphans with siblings. We’re destined to be together.”

The air in the room was still and hot. The windows closed, yet somewhere outside, a door opened and shut. She gazed at the window, wishing she could be out there and not in here.

“I need your help, Rose.”

“With?”

“Tell me the value of a Russian.”

The clock ticked on. It would soon be eight. Now he was rambling about Russians again. Previously, he’d blamed them for Felix’s death and promised retribution. Rose decided he’d drunk too much, and she should leave. She stood. “Please forgive me, I must—”

“Sit down,” he ordered, gesturing with his index finger to the chair.

Beads of sweat gathered on her back. She glanced at the closed window, debating whether to cross the room and open it for relief, but she forced herself to remain seated, knowing disobedience could provoke him.

“How many Russian lives equal a German one?”

“I don’t know.” Her mind raced—what was he talking about?